Principles of Bioethics

AUTONOMY

Respect informed choices and decision-making capacity.

BENEFICENCE

Act in the patient's best interests.

NON-MALEFICENCE

Avoid preventable harm and unnecessary risk.

JUSTICE

Provide fair care and use resources responsibly.

CONFIDENTIALITY

Protect health information in all settings.

PROFESSIONAL INTEGRITY

Disclose conflicts and maintain appropriate boundaries.

Areas of Bioethics

CLINICAL ETHICS

Decisions about diagnosis, treatment, consent, capacity, confidentiality and end-of-life care.

RESEARCH ETHICS

Protection of participants, scientific integrity, informed consent and responsible conduct.

PUBLIC HEALTH ETHICS

Fair decisions that balance individual rights with population health needs.

Ethical reasoning asks what should be done, why it is justified and how it should be carried out.

Barriers to Ethical Practice

UNCERTAINTY

Complex illness and unclear outcomes can make decisions difficult.

COMMUNICATION

Limited time, language barriers and weak communication may prevent understanding.

FEAR

Concern about the patient's reaction may delay honest discussion.

ASSUMPTIONS

Deciding what is best without exploring the patient's values can undermine autonomy.

Use clear communication, interpreters, teamwork and ethics consultation when needed.